“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Madhya-līlā

Chapter 20

The Truth of the Svarūpa: A Discourse on the Distinctions among the Forms of Śrī Bhagavān

(English translation from the Bengali, following the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition and the Anubhāṣya, 2026)

1 I bow down to Śrī Caitanya Mahāprabhu, whose opulence is boundless and wondrous. By His mercy even the lowly may bring forth the scriptures of devotion.[1]

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra! Glory to all the devotees of Gaura![2]

3 Meanwhile, in Gauḍa, Sanātana was still in prison when a letter from Śrī Rūpa Gosvāmī reached him.

4 Sanātana was delighted to receive the letter, and he began to speak to the yavana who guarded him:

5 “You are a *jindā-pīr*, a living saint, and greatly fortunate. You are learned in the Koran and the other scriptures.

6 If someone, true to his own religion, releases a prisoner, the Lord frees him from worldly existence.

7 I have done you favours in the past. Now release me and return the favour.

8 Please accept five thousand coins. You will gain twice over — merit and wealth.”

9 The yavana replied, “Listen, sir. I would release you, but I fear the king.”

10–11 Sanātana said, “Do not fear the king. He has gone south. If he comes back, tell him that I went out to relieve myself and, coming near the Gaṅgā and seeing it, jumped in.

12 Tell him that you searched long but found no trace of me — that I drowned with my fetters on and was carried away somewhere.

13 There is nothing to fear: I shall not stay in this land. I shall become a dervish and go to Mecca.”

14 Still Sanātana saw that the yavana was not satisfied, so he heaped seven thousand coins before him.

15 At the sight of the coins the yavana grew greedy. That night he cut off Sanātana’s fetters and took him across the Gaṅgā.

16 Sanātana avoided the road through the fort gate, for he could not go that way. Walking night and day, he came to the Pātaḍā hills.

17 There lived a landholder (*bhaumika*). Sanātana went to him and humbly asked, “Please take me across the hills.”[3]

18 With that landholder was a palmist. Perceiving the matter, he whispered into the landholder’s ear,

19 “This man has eight gold mohurs.” Hearing this, the landholder was delighted and said to Sanātana,

20 “Tonight I will have my own men take you across the hills. Meanwhile, cook and have your meal.”

21 With these words he respectfully gave him food grains, and Sanātana went and bathed in the river.

22 Having fasted for two days, he cooked and ate. But Sanātana, once a royal minister, began to reflect:

23 “Why has this landholder shown me such respect?” Thinking this, Sanātana asked Īśāna,

24 “I know you have some valuables with you.” Īśāna replied, “I have seven mohurs.”

25 Hearing this, Sanātana rebuked him: “Why have you brought this death along with you?”

26 Then he took the seven mohurs in his hand, went to the landholder and, holding out the coins, said,

27 “I had these seven gold mohurs. Take them, and as a matter of religious duty take me across the hills.

28 I am the king’s prisoner and cannot go by the fort gate. You will earn merit — take me across the hills.”

29 The landholder smiled and said, “I knew it already: your servant has eight mohurs tied in the hem of his cloth.

30 Tonight I would have killed you and taken the mohurs. It is good that you told me — I have been spared that sin.

31 I am pleased. I will not take the mohurs. For the sake of merit alone I will take you across the hills."

32 Sanātana Gosvāmī said, "Someone else will kill me for these valuables. Accept them and save my life."

33 Then the landholder sent four armed men with him, and night after night they led him across the hills along forest paths.

34 Having crossed, Sanātana Gosvāmī asked Īśāna, "I know you still have something left with you."

35 Īśāna replied, "One mohur is left." Sanātana Gosvāmī said, "Take the mohur and go home."

36 Sending him away, Sanātana Gosvāmī went on alone. With nothing but a water pot in his hand and a torn quilt, he was now free from fear.

37 Walking on and on, Sanātana Gosvāmī came to Hājipura, and in the evening he sat down in a garden.

38 In Hājipura lived Śrīkānta, the husband of Sanātana's sister, who was in the king's service.

39 The king had given him three hundred thousand coins; with this money he bought horses and sent them to the emperor.

40 Sitting on a tower, Śrīkānta saw Sanātana Gosvāmī, and at night he came to him with one attendant.

41 The two met there and talked intimately, and Sanātana Gosvāmī told him the whole story of his imprisonment and release.

42 Śrīkānta said, “Stay here a couple of days. Make yourself presentable and give up these dirty clothes.”

43 Sanātana Gosvāmī said, “I will not stay here even a moment. Take me across the Gaṅgā; I must go at once.”

44 Śrīkānta lovingly gave him a woollen Bhoṭa blanket and took him across the Gaṅgā, and Sanātana Gosvāmī went on his way.

45 After some days Sanātana Gosvāmī reached Vārāṇasī, and he was overjoyed to hear that the Lord had arrived there.

46 He came to Candraśekhara’s house and sat down at the door. Mahāprabhu knew this and said to Candraśekhara,

47 “There is a Vaiṣṇava at the door. Call him in.” Candraśekhara looked, but saw no Vaiṣṇava at the door.

48 He told the Lord, “There is no Vaiṣṇava at the door.” The Lord asked him, “Is anyone there at all?”

49 He replied, “There is a dervish at the door.” “Bring him in,” said the Lord, and at His word Candraśekhara came out and said to him,

50 “The Lord is calling you. Come in, dervish!” Hearing this, Sanātana joyfully went in.

51 Seeing him in the courtyard, the Lord came running, embraced him and was overwhelmed with love.

52 At the Lord's touch Sanātana too was overwhelmed with love. In a voice choked with emotion he said, "Do not touch me!"

53 Embracing each other, the two wept without end, and Candraśekhara was amazed to see it.

54 Then the Lord took him by the hand, led him in and seated him beside Himself on a raised platform.

55 With His own hand the Lord wiped Sanātana's body clean. Sanātana said, "O Lord, do not touch me!"

56 The Lord said, "I touch you to purify Myself, for by the power of your devotion you can purify the entire universe."

57 "Devotees such as you are themselves holy places, my lord. By the Lord who dwells within your hearts, you make even the holy places holy." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.13.10)[4]

58 "Even a knower of the four Vedas is not dear to Me if he is not devoted to Me, but My devotee is dear to Me even if he was born a dog-eater. One should give to him and accept from him; he is to be worshipped just as I am." (Itihāsa-samuccaya, quoted in Hari-bhakti-vilāsa, 10.91)[5]

59 "I consider a dog-eater whose mind, words, deeds, wealth and very life are offered to the Lord of the lotus navel better than a brāhmaṇa endowed with the twelve qualities who has turned away from His lotus feet. Such a devotee purifies his whole family; the brāhmaṇa swollen with pride cannot." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 7.9.10)[6]

60 "To see you, to touch you and to sing your qualities is the fruit of all the senses; such is the verdict of the scriptures."

61 “The fruit of the eyes is to see one like you; the fruit of the body is to touch the body of one like you; the fruit of the tongue is to glorify one like you. Pure devotees of the Lord are very rare in this world.” (Hari-bhakti-sudhodaya, 13.2)

62 Having said this, the Lord continued, “Listen, Sanātana. Kṛṣṇa is most merciful; He is the purifier of the fallen.

63 He has delivered you from the hell called Mahā-raurava. Kṛṣṇa is an ocean of mercy, deep and boundless.”

64 Sanātana replied, “I do not know Kṛṣṇa. I consider Your mercy alone the cause of my deliverance.”

65 The Lord asked, “How did you escape?” and Sanātana told Him the whole story from beginning to end.

66 The Lord said, “I met your two brothers, Rūpa and Anupama, in Prayāga. Both have gone on to Vṛndāvana.”

67 At the Lord’s bidding Sanātana met both Tapana Miśra and Candraśekhara.

68 Tapana Miśra then invited him for his meals, and the Lord said, “Go and have a shave, Sanātana.”

69 Calling Candraśekhara, the Lord said, “Take him with you and remove this garb.”

70 Candraśekhara had him shaved and bathed in the Gaṅgā, and then brought him new cloth.

71 Sanātana did not accept that cloth, and when the Lord heard this, His joy knew no bounds.

72 Having finished His midday duties, the Lord went to take His meal, and He took Sanātana with Him to Tapana Miśra's house.

73 After washing His feet He sat down for the meal and said to Miśra, "Serve Sanātana too."

74 Miśra said, "Sanātana has something to attend to. Please take Your meal; I will give him prasāda afterwards."

75 After the meal Mahāprabhu lay down to rest, and Miśra gave Sanātana the plate with the Lord's remnants.

76 Miśra offered Sanātana new cloth, but he would not take it. Instead he made a request:

77 "If you wish to give me cloth, give me one of your own that is old."

78 Then Miśra gave him an old dhoti, and Sanātana made it into two sets of outer cloth (*bahirvāsa*) and loincloth (*kaupīna*).

79 The Lord introduced Sanātana to a brāhmaṇa from Mahārāṣṭra, and that brāhmaṇa gave him a standing invitation:

80 "Sanātana, as long as you stay in Kāśī, please take your meals at my house."

81 Sanātana said, "I shall live by *mādhukarī*, begging a little from house to house. Why should I take all my meals at one brāhmaṇa's house?"

82 The Lord was boundlessly pleased by Sanātana's renunciation, yet again and again He glanced at the woollen Bhoṭa blanket.

83 Sanātana understood that the Lord did not like it, and he thought of a way to give the blanket up.

84 With this in mind he went to the Gaṅgā for his midday bath. There a Bengali had washed his quilt and spread it out to dry.

85 Sanātana said to him, "Brother, do me a favour: take this blanket and give me this quilt."

86 The man said, "Are you, a respectable gentleman, joking with me? Why would you give a costly blanket in exchange for a quilt?"

87 Sanātana said, "I am not joking; I am telling the truth. Take the blanket and give me your quilt."

88 With these words he took the quilt in exchange for the blanket and, throwing it over his shoulders, came back to the Lord.

89 The Lord asked, "Where has your Bhoṭa blanket gone?" and at the Lord's feet Sanātana Gosvāmī told Him the whole story.

90–91 The Lord said, "I have thought about this. Kṛṣṇa has destroyed your disease of worldliness — why would He leave you this last bit of worldly enjoyment? Once a good physician has cured a disease, he leaves no trace of it behind.

92 To wear a blanket worth three gold coins while living on *mādhukarī* is a breach of religious principle, and people laugh at it."

93 Sanātana Gosvāmī said, “By the will of Him who destroyed my sinful worldly enjoyment, the last of my worldly disease is gone.”

94 The Lord was pleased and bestowed His mercy on him, and by that mercy Sanātana gained the power to ask questions.

95 Just as earlier the Lord had put questions to Rāya Rāmānanda, and Rāmānanda had answered them by the Lord’s own power,

96 so now Sanātana asked questions by the Lord’s power, and Mahāprabhu Himself explained the truth.

97 Out of His mercy the Lord taught Sanātana the truth of Kṛṣṇa’s own nature, His sweetness and majesty, and the rasa of devotion.[7]

98 Then Sanātana clasped the Lord’s feet and, holding a straw between his teeth, humbly entreated Him:

99 “I am low-born, I keep low company, I am fallen and wretched. Fallen into the well of sinful worldliness, I have wasted my life.

100 I know nothing of what is good or harmful for me. I am learned only in worldly dealings, and I take that for the truth.

101 Since You in Your mercy have delivered me, tell me, by that same mercy, what my duty is.

102 Who am I? Why do the threefold miseries burn me? I do not know this, nor how I may attain my true good.

103 I do not even know how to ask about the truth of the goal (*sādhya*) and the means (*sādhana*). Be merciful and explain all these truths Yourself.”

104 The Lord said, “Kṛṣṇa’s mercy rests on you in full. You know all these truths, and the threefold miseries do not touch you.

105 You possess devotion to Kṛṣṇa and know the essence of all the truths. Yet a sādhu, though he knows, still asks in order to make his understanding firm — such is his nature.

106 “Those whose minds are set with perseverance on understanding true religion soon attain every aim they desire.” (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, Pūrva-vibhāga, Sādhana-bhakti-laharī, 47)[8]

107 You are a worthy vessel for propagating devotion. Now hear all the truths in order as I tell them to you.

108 The true nature (*svarūpa*) of the jīva is to be Kṛṣṇa’s eternal servant. The jīva is Kṛṣṇa’s marginal potency (*taṭasthā-śakti*), a manifestation that is both different and not different from Him (*bhedābheda-prakāśa*).

109 The jīva is like a ray of the sun or a spark of fire. By His very nature Kṛṣṇa has three kinds of potency.

110 “As the light of a fire burning in one place spreads all around, so this entire world is the potency of the Supreme Brahman.” (Viṣṇu Purāṇa, 1.22.53)[9]

111 Kṛṣṇa’s natural potency manifests in three ways: the spiritual potency (*cit-śakti*), the jīva potency (*jīva-śakti*) and the potency of māyā (*māyā-śakti*).

112 “The potency of Viṣṇu is declared to be superior; the potency called the knower of the field (*kṣetrajña*) is likewise superior; and the other, called ignorance and karma, is held to be a third potency.” (Viṣṇu Purāṇa, 6.7.61)[10]

113 “The potencies of all things are inconceivable to ordinary knowledge. Therefore, O best of ascetics, Brahman possesses natural potencies for creation and the rest, just as fire possesses heat.” (Viṣṇu Purāṇa, 1.3.2)

114 “O king, the potency called the knower of the field can enter both spirit and matter; yet here, enveloped by that ignorance, it suffers without end all the miseries of worldly existence.” (Viṣṇu Purāṇa, 6.7.62)[11]

115 “Because it is covered by that ignorance, O king, the potency called the knower of the field exists in all beings in varying degrees.” (Viṣṇu Purāṇa, 6.7.63)[12]

116 “This nature is inferior. But know, O mighty-armed, that I have another, superior nature, consisting of the jīvas, who take up this world for their own enjoyment.” (Bhagavad-gītā, 7.5)[13]

117 Having forgotten Kṛṣṇa, the jīva has turned its face from Him since time without beginning. Therefore māyā gives it the miseries of worldly existence.

118 Sometimes she raises it to heaven, sometimes she sinks it into hell — just as a king has a condemned man dunked again and again in a river.

119 “For one who has turned away from the Lord, fear arises from absorption in what is other than Him; by His māyā come forgetfulness of the Lord and a false idea of oneself. Therefore the wise, seeing the guru as his worshipful deity and his very self, should worship the Lord with exclusive devotion.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.2.37)

120 If by the mercy of the sādhus and the scriptures the jīva turns towards Kṛṣṇa, it crosses over, and māyā releases it.

121 “This divine māyā of Mine, made of the guṇas, is hard to overcome. But those who surrender to Me alone cross beyond this māyā.” (Bhagavad-gītā, 7.14)

122 The jīva bewildered by māyā has no remembrance or knowledge of Kṛṣṇa. So, out of mercy for the jīva, Kṛṣṇa made the Vedas and Purāṇas.

123 He makes Himself known in the form of scripture, the guru and the Supersoul, and the jīva comes to know: “Kṛṣṇa is my Lord and protector.”

124 The Vedic scriptures speak of *sambandha*, *abhidheya* and *prayojana*. Kṛṣṇa, the one to be attained, is the *sambandha*; devotion (bhakti) is the means of attaining Him.

125 Bhakti is called the *abhidheya*, and prema is the *prayojana*. Prema, the crown jewel of all human goals, is the greatest treasure.

126 Prema is what brings one the bliss of serving Kṛṣṇa in His sweetness: through it one serves Kṛṣṇa and tastes the rasa of Kṛṣṇa.

127 Here is an illustration: an all-knowing sage (*sarvajña*) came to a poor man’s house and, seeing his misery, asked him,

128 ‘Why are you so miserable? You have your father’s treasure. He did not tell you about it because he died far from home.’

129 Guided by the sage’s words, the poor man set out to find the treasure. In the same way the Vedas and Purāṇas teach the jīva about Kṛṣṇa.

130 By the sage’s words the poor man learned of his link with the original treasure; so too all the scriptures teach that Śrī Kṛṣṇa is the *sambandha*.

131 Merely knowing that his father's wealth was there did not bring it to him, so the sage told him how to obtain it:

132 'The treasure is here in this place. If you dig on the south side, hornets and wasps will rise up and you will not get the treasure.[14]

133 If you dig on the west side, there is a *yakṣa* there; he will obstruct you, and your hand will never touch the treasure.

134 If you dig on the north side, there is a black python; you will not get the treasure — it will swallow everyone who digs.

135 But on the east side, as soon as you dig away a little earth, the pot of treasure will fall into your hands.'

136 So too the scriptures say: give up karma, jñāna and yoga. Kṛṣṇa is won by devotion; worship Him, then, with devotion.

137 (Śrī Kṛṣṇa said:) "O Uddhava, neither yoga nor sāṅkhya, neither dharma nor study of the Vedas, neither austerity nor renunciation can win Me as intense devotion to Me does." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.14.20)[15]

138 "I, the dear Self of the saintly, am attained by single-minded devotion born of faith. Devotion fixed on Me purifies even dog-eaters from the stain of their birth." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.14.21)

139 Therefore devotion is the way to attain Kṛṣṇa, and all the scriptures sing of it as *abhidheya*, the means.

140 When a man gains wealth, he enjoys its fruit, happiness, and in that enjoyment sorrow flees of itself.

141 So too, as the fruit of devotion, love (prema) for Kṛṣṇa arises; and when Kṛṣṇa is tasted in love, worldly existence comes to an end.

142 The end of poverty and the end of worldly existence are not the 'fruit' of love. To enjoy the happiness of love is the chief goal (*prayojana*).

143 The Vedic scriptures speak of *sambandha*, *abhidheya* and *prayojana*: Kṛṣṇa, devotion to Kṛṣṇa and love — these are the three great treasures.

144 In the Vedas and all the scriptures Kṛṣṇa is the chief *sambandha*. When He is known, the bonds of māyā fall away of themselves.

145 "To bewilder the world of moving and unmoving beings, let the various Purāṇas and Āgamas prattle until the end of the *kalpa* that this or that deity is supreme. But when the teachings of all the scriptures are carefully weighed and compared, the conclusion is certain: Viṣṇu alone is Bhagavān." (Padma Purāṇa, Vaiśākha-māhātmya, the conversation of Yama and a brāhmaṇa)[16]

146 Whether by the primary or the secondary sense of words, or by affirmation and negation, the declaration of the Vedas speaks only of Kṛṣṇa.

147 "What does the Veda enjoin? What does it declare? Of what does it speak when it weighs alternatives? No one in the world but Me knows its heart." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.21.42)

148 "It enjoins Me, it declares Me; and what it considers and then sets aside is also Me. This is the meaning of all the Vedas: resting on Me, the Veda names the differences of this world as mere māyā, negates them, and in the end comes to rest." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.21.43)

149 Kṛṣṇa's own nature (*svarūpa*) is infinite, His splendour boundless: the spiritual potency (*cit-śakti*), the potency of māyā (*māyā-śakti*) and the po-

tency of the jīvas (*jīva-śakti*) are all His.

150 Vaikuṇṭha and the countless universes are the works of these potencies. Of His own potency (*svarūpa-śakti*) and of all the works of His potencies, Kṛṣṇa is the shelter.

151 "In the Tenth Canto the tenth subject is revealed: the embodiment of the shelter of all who take shelter, the supreme abode named Śrī Kṛṣṇa, the abode of the world. To That I bow down." (Śrīdhara Svāmī, *Bhāvārtha-dīpikā* on Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.1.1)[17]

152 Now hear, Sanātana, the truth about Kṛṣṇa's own nature (*svarūpa*). He is the Truth of non-dual knowledge, and in Vraja He is the son of the king of Vraja.

153 He is the origin of all and the source of all parts (*aṁśī*), the crown of youths. His body is spirit and bliss; He is the shelter of all and the Lord of all.

154 "Kṛṣṇa, Govinda, is the Supreme Lord; His form is eternal being, knowledge and bliss. He has no beginning, yet He is the beginning of all, the cause of all causes." (Brahma-saṁhitā, 5.1)[18]

155 Kṛṣṇa is Bhagavān Himself; 'Govinda' is His supreme name. He is full of all opulence, and Goloka is His eternal abode.

156 "All these (avatāras) are portions (*aṁśa*) and parts of portions (*kalā*) of the Puruṣa, but Kṛṣṇa is Bhagavān Himself. Age after age They bring happiness to the world when it is troubled by the enemies of Indra." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.3.28)[19]

157 According to the three practices — knowledge, yoga and devotion — He is manifest in three ways: as Brahman, Paramātmā and Bhagavān.

158 “The knowers of the Truth call the non-dual knowledge the Truth; it is named Brahman, Paramātmā and Bhagavān.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.2.11)[20]

159 Brahman is the effulgence of His body, His featureless manifestation — just as the sun appears to the fleshly eye as nothing but light.

160 “I worship Govinda, the original Person. Brahman — undivided, infinite and complete, distinct from all the opulences of countless universes, their earths and all else — is the effulgence of Him, the Almighty.” (Brahma-saṁhitā, 5.40)[21]

161 The Paramātmā is one part of Kṛṣṇa, and Kṛṣṇa, the crown of all, is the Soul of the soul.

162 “Know this Kṛṣṇa to be the Soul of all souls. For the good of the world He appears here, by His own potency, as if He were an embodied being.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.14.55)

163 “But what need have you, Arjuna, of all this detailed knowledge? By one portion of Myself I pervade and support this entire universe.” (Bhagavad-gītā, 10.42)[22]

164 Through devotion Bhagavān is realised in His full form: in His one form are His infinite forms.

165 First of all, Bhagavān abides in three forms, named *svayaṁ-rūpa*, *tad-ekātma-rūpa* and *āveśa*.

166 The original form shines forth in two ways, as the *svayaṁ-rūpa* and as the *svayaṁ-prakāśa*. As the *svayaṁ-rūpa*, the one Kṛṣṇa is a cowherd in Vraja.

167 The *svayaṁ-prakāśa* shows itself in two ways, as *prābhava* and *vaibhava*. Thus in the rāsa dance His one body became many forms.

168 And at His marriages with the queens He appeared in forms of many kinds. This is the *vaibhava-prakāśa*, as is well known in the scriptures.

169 These forms are not a multiplication of the body (*kāya-vyūha*) like that of Saubhari and others; if they were, Nārada would not have been struck with wonder.

170 "How wonderful! The one Kṛṣṇa, in one and the same body, married sixteen thousand princesses at once, each in her own palace." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.69.2)[23]

171 When that same body, that same form, appears separately, differing only in the emotion (*bhāva*) that absorbs it, it is called *vaibhava-prakāśa*.

172 In Kṛṣṇa's infinite manifestations there is no difference in His person; they bear different names according to differences of shape, colour and weapons.

173 "Others, purified by the rules You Yourself have enjoined and absorbed in You, worship You alone, who have many forms and yet are one form." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.40.7)

174 Śrī Balarāma is the *vaibhava-prakāśa* of Kṛṣṇa. They differ only in colour; in all else He is equal to Kṛṣṇa.

175 Another *vaibhava-prakāśa* is the son of Devakī: sometimes His form is two-armed, and sometimes He is four-armed.

176 When He is two-armed, He is called *vaibhava-prakāśa*; when He becomes four-armed, He is called *prābhava-vilāsa*.

177 The *svayaṁ-rūpa* wears a cowherd's dress and thinks of Himself as a cowherd; Vāsudeva wears a kṣatriya's dress and is aware, 'I am a kṣatriya.'

178 In the son of the king of Vraja, beauty, majesty, sweetness and the play of His artfulness (*vaidagdhya*) bring still greater delight.

179 Seeing Govinda's sweetness, Vāsudeva is stirred, and a longing arises in Him to taste that sweetness —

180 as in Mathurā, when He watched the dance of the Gandharvas, and again in Dvārakā, when He beheld a picture.

181 (Vāsudeva said:) "O friend, again and again this actor works wonders, showing a double of Me in My cowherd pastimes, which overflow with the fragrance of wondrous sweetness. Ah, when I see how like Me he is, My heart, stirred by eagerness for such play, truly longs for a form like that of the girls of Vraja." (Lalita-mādhava, 4.19)[24]

182 "May this wondrous flood of My sweetness, never known before and surpassing all, shine forth! Alas, seeing it, even I long with an eager heart to enjoy it, as Rādhikā does." (Lalita-mādhava, 8.34)[25]

183 When that same body appears in another guise, somewhat different in shape, with a different *bhāva* absorbing it and different features, it is called *tad-ekātma*.

184 The *tad-ekātma-rūpa* has two divisions, *vilāsa* and *svāṁśa*, and each of them has many varieties.

185 *Vilāsa* is of two kinds, *prābhava* and *vaibhava*, and *vilāsa* has its own *vilāsas* without number.

186 The *prābhava-vilāsas* are Vāsudeva, Saṅkarṣaṇa, Pradyumna and Aniruddha — the chief four.

187 In Vraja Rāma has the mood of a cowherd; in the city, the self-awareness of a kṣatriya. Because His colour and dress differ, He is called *vilāsa*.

188 In one and the same form Baladeva appears both as *vaibhava-prakāśa* and as *prābhava-vilāsa*, according to the difference of mood.[26]

189 No one is equal to the original *catur-vyūha*; They are the cause of the appearance of countless *catur-vyūhas*.

190 These four are Kṛṣṇa's *prābhava-vilāsas*; They reside eternally in the cities of Dvārakā and Mathurā.

191 From these four, twenty-four forms are manifest. Their names differ according to their weapons; They are the *vaibhava-vilāsas*.

192 Again Kṛṣṇa, taking the *catur-vyūha* with Him as before, resides in the spiritual sky (*paravyoma*) in the form of Nārāyaṇa.

193 From Him a *catur-vyūha* is manifest once more; They reside on the four sides as His enclosure (*āvaraṇa*).[27]

194 Again, each of the four has three separate forms — Keśava and the others — by whom the *vilāsas* are completed.

195 All Their names differ according to how They hold the disc and the other weapons. Vāsudeva's forms are Keśava, Nārāyaṇa and Mādhava.

196 Saṅkarṣaṇa's forms are Govinda, Viṣṇu and Madhusūdana. This is another Govinda, not the son of the king of Vraja.

197 Pradyumna's forms are Trivikrama, Vāmana and Śrīdhara; Aniruddha's forms are Hṛṣīkeśa, Padmanābha and Dāmodara.

198 These twelve are the Deities of the twelve months: in Mārgaśīrṣa, Keśava; in Pauṣa, Nārāyaṇa;

199 the Deity of Māgha is Mādhava, and of Phālguna, Govinda; in Caitra, Viṣṇu; in Vaiśākha, Śrī Madhusūdana;

200 in Jyaiṣṭha, Trivikrama; in Āṣāḍha, Vāmana, the Lord of the gods; in Śrāvaṇa, Śrīdhara; in Bhādra, Lord Hṛṣīkeśa;

201 in Āśvina, Padmanābha; in Kārttika, Dāmodara. Rādhā-Dāmodara, the son of the king of Vraja, is another.

202 These twelve names are the twelve mantras for *tilaka*; in *ācamana* one touches the respective places of the body with these names.

203 These four have eight further *vilāsa* forms. I shall tell you all Their names; hear, Sanātana.

204 Puruṣottama, Acyuta, Nṛsiṁha, Janārdana, Hari, Kṛṣṇa, Adhokṣaja and Upendra — these are the eight.

205 Vāsudeva's two *vilāsas* are Adhokṣaja and Puruṣottama, and Saṅkarṣaṇa's are Upendra and Acyuta.

206 Pradyumna's *vilāsas* are Nṛsiṁha and Janārdana, and Aniruddha's are Hari and Kṛṣṇa.

207 These twenty-four forms are the chief *vaibhava-vilāsas*. According to how They hold Their weapons, They bear different names.

208 Those among Them who differ in shape and dress are varieties of *vilāsa* and *vaibhava*.

209 Padmanābha, Trivikrama, Nṛsiṁha, Vāmana, Hari, Kṛṣṇa and others are distinctive in shape.

210 Kṛṣṇa's *prābhava-vilāsas* are the four, Vāsudeva and the others, and Their *vilāsas* number twenty.

211 Each of Them has His own Vaikuṇṭha in the spiritual sky, three in each of the eight directions, in order, beginning with the east.

212 Although the spiritual sky is the eternal abode of all of Them, some of Them are also present in places within the universe.

213 Within the spiritual sky Nārāyaṇa eternally resides; above the spiritual sky is the splendour of Kṛṣṇaloka.

214 The one Kṛṣṇaloka is of three kinds: Gokula, Mathurā and Dvārakā.

215 Keśava is eternally present in Mathurā; in Nīlācala it is Puruṣottama, named Jagannātha.

216 At Prayāga He is Mādhava; at Mandāra, Śrī Madhusūdana; at Ānandāraṇya, Vāsudeva, Padmanābha and Janārdana.

217 At Viṣṇu-kāñcī He is Viṣṇu, and Hari stays at Māyāpura. In the same way there are various other forms within the universe.

218 In this way all of Them are manifest within the universe, and Their pastimes take place in the seven *dvīpas* and the nine *khaṇḍas*.

219 He is manifest everywhere to give joy to His devotees, to destroy the irreligion of the world and to establish dharma.

220 Some of Them are counted among the avatāras, such as Viṣṇu, Trivikrama, Nṛsiṁha and Vāmana.

221 The different ways of holding the weapons are the cause of the different names. Hear, Sanātana, how differently They hold the disc and the rest.

222 The count of how They hold the disc and the other weapons begins with the lower right hand and ends with the lower left.

223 The *Siddhārtha-saṁhitā* enumerates twenty-four forms. First I shall tell, according to it, how They hold the disc and the rest.

224 Vāsudeva holds the mace, conch, disc and lotus; Saṅkarṣaṇa, the mace, conch, lotus and disc.

225 Pradyumna holds the disc, conch, mace and lotus; Aniruddha, the disc, mace, conch and lotus.

226 In the spiritual sky Vāsudeva and the others each hold Their own weapons; following that scripture, I shall tell which weapons each of Them holds.

227 Śrī Keśava holds the lotus, conch, disc and mace; Nārāyaṇa, the conch, lotus, mace and disc.

228 Śrī Mādhava holds the mace, disc, conch and lotus; Śrī Govinda, the disc, mace, lotus and conch.

229 The form of Viṣṇu holds the mace, lotus, conch and disc; Madhusūdana, the disc, conch, lotus and mace.

230 Trivikrama holds the lotus, mace, disc and conch; Śrī Vāmana, the conch, disc, mace and lotus.

231 Śrīdhara holds the lotus, disc, mace and conch; Hṛṣīkeśa, the mace, disc, lotus and conch.

232 Padmanābha holds the conch, lotus, disc and mace; Dāmodara, the lotus, disc, mace and conch.

233 Puruṣottama holds the disc, lotus, conch and mace; Śrī Acyuta, the mace, lotus, disc and conch.

234 Śrī Nṛsiṁha holds the disc, lotus, mace and conch; Janārdana, the lotus, disc, conch and mace.

235 Śrī Hari holds the conch, disc, lotus and mace; Śrī Kṛṣṇa, the conch, mace, lotus and disc.

236 Adhokṣaja holds the lotus, mace, conch and disc; Upendra, the conch, mace, disc and lotus.

237 The *Hayaśīrṣa Pañcarātra* speaks of sixteen forms. Now I shall tell, according to it, how They hold the disc and the rest.

238 There Keśava holds the lotus, conch, mace and disc, and Mādhava the disc, mace, conch and lotus.

239 Nārāyaṇa and the others hold Their weapons in various other ways; such are the differences in the weapons They hold.

240 The son of the king of Vraja bears these two names: ‘Svayaṁ Bhagavān’ and ‘Līlā-puruṣottama.’

241 Nine forms, the *nava-vyūha*, are manifest in nine places around the city as its enclosure (*āvaraṇa*).[28]

242 “The four — Vāsudeva and the others — Nārāyaṇa and Nṛsiṁha, Hayagrīva, Varāha and Brahmā: these are declared to be the nine.” (Laghu-bhāgavatāmṛta, 1.451)

243 Thus I have described the *prakāśas* and *vilāsas*. Now hear, Sanātana, the divisions of the *svāṁśa*.

244 It has two divisions: Saṅkarṣaṇa, and Matsya and the rest. Saṅkarṣaṇa is the *puruṣa-avatāra*; Matsya and the rest are the *līlā-avatāras*.

245 Kṛṣṇa’s avatāras are of six kinds: the *puruṣa-avatāras*, the *līlā-avatāras*,

246 the *guṇa-avatāras*, the *manvantara-avatāras*, the *yuga-avatāras* and the *śaktyāveśa-avatāras*.

247 Childhood (*bālya*) and boyhood (*paugaṇḍa*) are characteristics of His form; as a child and as a boy the son of the king of Vraja reveals His pastimes.

248 Kṛṣṇa’s avatāras are countless; there is no counting them. As one shows the moon by pointing to a branch, I shall give only an indication.[29]

249 “O brāhmaṇas, the avatāras of Hari, the treasure-house of goodness (*sattva*), are innumerable, like the thousands of rivulets that flow from an inexhaustible lake.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.3.26)[30]

250 First of all Kṛṣṇa manifests the *puruṣa-avatāra*, and that Puruṣa is of three kinds.

251 “Viṣṇu has three forms called Puruṣas: the first creates the mahat, the second abides within the universe, and the third dwells in all beings. Knowing Them, one is set free.” (Sātvata-tantra; Laghu-bhāgavatāmṛta, Pūrva-khaṇḍa, 2.9)[31]

252 Among Kṛṣṇa’s infinite potencies three are chief, named *icchā-śakti*, *jñāna-śakti* and *kriyā-śakti* — the potencies of will, knowledge and action.

253 Kṛṣṇa, in whom the potency of will predominates, is by His will the doer of all. Vāsudeva, in whom the potency of knowledge predominates, is the presiding Lord of the *citta*, consciousness.

254 Without will, knowledge and action there is no creation; the world is fashioned when these three join Their three potencies.

255 Saṅkarṣaṇa Balarāma, in whom the potency of action predominates, brings about both the material and the spiritual creation.[32]

256 As the presiding Lord of *ahaṅkāra*, He creates Goloka and Vaikuṇṭha by Kṛṣṇa’s will, through the spiritual potency (*cit-śakti*).

257 Although the display of the spiritual potency is eternal and uncreated, it is manifest by the will of Saṅkarṣaṇa.

258 “The great abode called Gokula is a lotus with a thousand petals; its whorl is His abode, and it has arisen from a portion of Ananta.” (Brahma-saṁhitā, 5.2)

259 Through māyā He creates the host of universes; inert *prakṛti* is not the cause of the universe.

260 Without the Lord’s potency, creation cannot come from what is inert; therefore Saṅkarṣaṇa infuses potency into it.

261 By the Lord's potency *prakṛti* creates, just as iron obtains the power to burn by the potency of fire.

262 "Rāma and Mukunda are the seed and the womb of the universe — the Puruṣa and *pradhāna*. Having entered into all beings, these two primeval Lords rule over the diverse jīvas." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.46.31)[33]

263 The form of the Lord that descends into the world for creation bears the name avatāra.

264 All of Them dwell in the spiritual sky beyond māyā; when They descend into the world, They are called avatāras.

265 To glance at that māyā, Śrī Saṅkarṣaṇa first descended in the form of the Puruṣa.

266 "In the beginning, desiring to create the worlds, Bhagavān accepted the form of the Puruṣa, joined with the mahat and the other principles and possessed of sixteen potencies (*kalā*)." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.3.1)[34]

267 "The Puruṣa is the first avatāra of the Supreme. Time, nature, prakṛti as cause and effect, the mind, the elements, false ego, the guṇas, the senses, the universal body (*virāṭ*) and the Vairāja (*svarāṭ*), and all beings, moving and unmoving — all these are the splendour of the Great One." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.6.42)[35]

268 That Puruṣa lies upon the Virajā. He is named Kāraṇābdhiśāyī, the cause of the world.

269 Māyā abides eternally on the shore of the Causal Ocean; she has no access beyond the Virajā into the spiritual sky.

270 “There neither passion nor ignorance operates, nor goodness mixed with them, nor the might of time; there even māyā has no place — what to speak of the rest. There dwell the followers of Hari, worshipped by gods and *asuras* alike.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.9.10)[36]

271 Māyā has two functions, called māyā and *pradhāna*. Māyā is the efficient cause of the universe, and *pradhāna* is its material cause.

272 That Puruṣa turns His glance towards māyā. Agitating *prakṛti*, He deposits the seed in her.

273 He touches *prakṛti* only through a reflection of a particular part of His own body, and places in her the seed, which is the countless jīvas.

274 “When by time (*daiva*) the qualities of nature were stirred, the Supreme Person placed the seed in the womb of His own nature, and she gave birth to the golden *mahat-tattva*.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.26.19)[37]

275 “By the working of time the potent Adhokṣaja, through the Puruṣa, His own part, placed the seed in māyā, which is made of the *guṇas*.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.5.26)[38]

276 Then from the *mahat-tattva* came the threefold ego (*ahaṅkāra*), from which the gods, the senses and the elements spread forth.

277 All the elements combined and created multitudes of universes — endless universes, beyond all counting.

278 This Puruṣa, the creator of the *mahat*, is named Mahā-Viṣṇu. Countless universes dwell in the pores of His skin.

279 As specks of dust fly in and out through a lattice window, so the universes come out with the Puruṣa's breath.

280 And with His breath they go back inside again. His majesty is endless, and all of it lies beyond māyā.

281 "The lords of the universes, born from His pores, abide for the span of one of His breaths. That Mahā-Viṣṇu is a particular kalā of Govinda, the original Person, whom I worship." (Brahma-saṁhitā, 5.48)[39]

282 He is the indwelling Lord of all the multitudes of universes. Kāraṇābdhiśāyī is the master of all the worlds.

283 Thus I have told you the truth about the first Puruṣa. Now hear of the greatness of the second Puruṣa.

284 Having created endless millions of universes, that Puruṣa became many forms and entered each universe in a form of His own.

285 Entering, He saw that all was darkness and there was no place to stay, and He reflected.

286 With the water of His own body's perspiration He filled half the universe, and on those waters He lay down on the bed of Śeṣa.

287 From His navel-lotus a lotus arose, and that lotus became the birthplace of Brahmā.

288 In the stem of that lotus the fourteen worlds came to be, and He, becoming Brahmā, brought forth the creation.

289 Taking the form of Viṣṇu, He maintains the world. Viṣṇu is beyond the *guṇas*; He has no contact with māyā.

290 Assuming the form of Rudra, He destroys the world. Creation, maintenance and dissolution all take place by His will.

291 Brahmā, Viṣṇu and Śiva are His *guṇa-avatāras*. The three are in charge of creation, maintenance and dissolution.

292 Garbhodakaśāyī is the indwelling Lord of Hiraṇyagarbha. The Vedas sing of Him in the hymn that begins "thousand-headed" (*sahasra-śīrṣā*) and in others.

293 This second Puruṣa is the Lord of the universe. He is the shelter of māyā, yet He is beyond māyā.

294 The third Puruṣa, Viṣṇu, is also a *guṇa-avatāra*: He is counted among both kinds of avatāras.

295 He is the indwelling Lord of the *virāṭ* and of the individual jīvas. He is Kṣīrodakaśāyī, the maintainer and master.

296 Thus I have described the *puruṣa-avatāras*. Now, Sanātana, hear about the *līlā-avatāras*.

297 Kṛṣṇa's *līlā-avatāras* cannot be counted. I shall give only a glimpse, naming the chief ones.

298 Matsya, Kūrma, Raghunātha, Nṛsiṁha, Vāmana, Varāha and others — they are too many to write down and count.

299 "O Lord, descending as the Fish, the Horse, the Tortoise, Nṛsiṁha, the Boar and the Swan, and among kings, brāhmaṇas and gods, You protect us and the three worlds. So now, O best of the Yadus, remove the burden of the earth. We bow down to You." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.2.40)

300 I have given you a glimpse of the *līlā-avatāras*. Now hear the account of the *guṇa-avatāras*.

301 Brahmā, Viṣṇu and Śiva are the three *guṇa-avatāras*. Accepting the three *guṇas*, they carry out creation and the rest.

302 Through piety mixed with devotion, some excellent jīva has his mind imbued with *rajo-guṇa*,

303 and, infusing His power into him through Garbhodakaśāyī, Kṛṣṇa assumes the form of Brahmā and brings forth the individual creation.

304 "As the sun displays something of its own radiance in certain gems that are its own, so here He becomes Brahmā, who orders the universe. I worship Govinda, that original Person." (Brahma-saṁhitā, 5.49)

305 If in some *kalpa* no qualified jīva is found, then the Lord Himself becomes Brahmā by His part.

306 (Baladeva said:) "The guardians of all the worlds bear on their crowned heads the dust of His lotus feet, the holiest of holy places; and Brahmā, Śiva, Lakṣmī and I Myself, mere parts of His part, carry it on our heads forever. What then is a king's throne to Him?" (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.68.37)[40]

307 By a *kalā* of His own part Kṛṣṇa accepts *tamo-guṇa*; and to destroy the universe He joins with māyā and assumes the form of Rudra.

308 Through the change wrought by contact with māyā, Rudra's form is both different and not different from Kṛṣṇa; he is counted as *jīva-tattva*, not as Kṛṣṇa's own form (*svarūpa*).

309 When milk meets something sour, it takes the form of curd. Curd is nothing other than milk, yet it cannot be milk.

310 "As milk becomes curd through contact with a particular agent of change, yet the curd is not separate from its cause, so He, for a particular task, assumes the state of Śambhu (Śiva). I worship Govinda, that original Person." (Brahma-saṁhitā, 5.45)

311 Śiva is the companion of *māyā-śakti* and is absorbed in *tamo-guṇa*, whereas Viṣṇu, the Supreme Lord, is beyond māyā and beyond the *guṇas*.

312 "Śiva is eternally united with *śakti*. Covered by the *guṇas*, he bears three marks: he is the threefold ego — *vaikārika*, *taijasa* and *tāmasa*." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.88.3)

313 "Hari is directly beyond the *guṇas*: He is the Person transcendent to *prakṛti*. He sees all and witnesses all. One who worships Him becomes free of the *guṇas*." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.88.5)

314 For maintenance He descends as His own part (*svāṁśa*) in the form of Viṣṇu. He is the overseer of *sattva-guṇa*, and therefore He is beyond the māyā of the *guṇas*.

315 By nature He is full of majesty, almost equal to Kṛṣṇa. Kṛṣṇa is the whole (*aṁśī*), and He is a part (*aṁśa*) — so the Vedas sing.

316 "As the flame of one lamp, passing to another wick, shines as a lamp with the same qualities as the lamp it came from, so He shines forth as Viṣṇu. I worship Govinda, that original Person." (Brahma-saṁhitā, 5.46)

317 Brahmā and Śiva are *bhakta-avatāras* who carry out His orders, while Viṣṇu, who maintains the world, is Kṛṣṇa's own form (*svarūpa*).

318 “Appointed by Him, I create; under His control Hara (Śiva) destroys; and He, the bearer of the three potencies, maintains the universe in the form of the Puruṣa.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.6.32)

319 Now, Sanātana, hear about the *manvantara-avatāras*. Their number is countless — hear the reason.

320 In one day of Brahmā there are fourteen *manvantaras*, and in them the Lord brings forth these fourteen avatāras.

321 Fourteen in one day, four hundred and twenty in a month, and five thousand and forty in a year of Brahmā.

322 Brahmā’s life lasts a hundred years; so there are 504,000 *manvantara-avatāras*.

323 Count them in this way in the endless universes — and Brahmā’s whole life lasts but one breath of Mahā-Viṣṇu.

324 There is no limit to Mahā-Viṣṇu’s breaths. How, then, could one ever finish writing of the *manvantara-avatāras* alone?

325 In the Svāyambhuva *manvantara* the avatāra is named Yajña; in the Svārociṣa, Vibhu; in the Uttama, Satyasena; and in the Tāmasa, Hari.

326 In the Raivata, Vaikuṇṭha; in the Cākṣuṣa, Ajita; in the Vaivasvata, Vāmana; in the Sāvarṇya, Sārvabhauma; and in the Dakṣa-sāvarṇya, Ṛṣabha is counted.

327 In the Brahma-sāvarṇya, Viṣvaksena; in the Dharma-sāvarṇya, Dharmasetu; in the Rudra-sāvarṇya, Sudhāmā; and in the Deva-sāvarṇya, Yogeśvara.

328 In the Indra-sāvarṇya the name is Bṛhadbhānu. These are the names of the fourteen avatāras in the fourteen *manvantaras*.

329 Now, Sanātana, hear about the *yuga-avatāras*. The *yugas* are counted as Satya, Tretā, Dvāpara and Kali.

330 White, red, black and yellow — these are the four colours in turn. Assuming these four colours, Kṛṣṇa establishes the dharma of each age.

331 "Your son, who accepts a body in every age, has appeared in three colours — white, red and yellow; now He has become dark (*kṛṣṇa*)." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.8.13)[41]

332 In Satya-yuga, assuming a white form, He has people practise the dharma of meditation. It was He who mercifully gave Kardama a boon.

333 People qualified for knowledge meditate on Kṛṣṇa. Assuming a red colour, He has people perform sacrifice (*yajña*), the dharma of Tretā.

334 The worship of Kṛṣṇa's feet is the dharma of Dvāpara. In a dark (*kṛṣṇa*) colour He has people perform the worship of Kṛṣṇa.

335 "In Dvāpara the Lord is dark, clad in yellow and bearing His own weapons, and He is known by the Śrīvatsa and other marks and characteristics." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.5.27)[42]

336 "Obeisance to You, Vāsudeva, and obeisance to Saṅkarṣaṇa, Pradyumna and Aniruddha — to You, Bhagavān, obeisance." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.5.29)

337 With this mantra people worship Kṛṣṇa in Dvāpara. The congregational chanting of Kṛṣṇa's name (*saṅkīrtana*) is the dharma of Kali-yuga.

338 Then, assuming a yellow colour, He established it, and with His devotees He gave people loving devotion (*prema-bhakti*).

339 The son of the king of Vraja establishes the dharma, and in love the people sing and dance and perform saṅkīrtana.

340 "With sacrifices in which congregational chanting predominates, the wise worship the Lord who ever sings of Kṛṣṇa and whose lustre is not dark. He is always surrounded by His intimate companions (*aṅga*), His devotees (*upāṅga*), His weapons and His associates (*pārṣada*)." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.5.32)[43]

341 Whatever fruit comes in the other three *yugas* through meditation and the rest, that same fruit is obtained in Kali-yuga through Kṛṣṇa's name.

342 "O king, Kali is an ocean of faults, yet it has one great quality: simply by singing the glories of Kṛṣṇa one is freed from bondage and attains the Supreme." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 12.3.51)

343 "Whatever was attained in Kṛta by meditating on Viṣṇu, in Tretā by worshipping with sacrifices and in Dvāpara by serving the Deity, is attained in Kali by glorifying Hari." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 12.3.52)

344 "What one attains by meditating in Kṛta, by worshipping with sacrifices in Tretā and by worshipping the Deity in Dvāpara, one attains in Kali by chanting together the names of Keśava." (Viṣṇu Purāṇa, 6.2.17)

345 "The noble, who know its merit and take the essence, honour the age of Kali, for in it every goal of life is attained by saṅkīrtana alone." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.5.36)

346 When I write of the hosts of *guṇa-avatāras* as before, their number is countless; they cannot be counted.

347 Such is the account of the avatāras of the four *yugas*." Hearing it, Sanātana questioned Him with a hidden intent (*bhaṅgi*).

348 Sanātana had been the king's minister, a Bṛhaspati in intelligence. By the Lord's mercy he asked without hesitation:

349 "I am a very insignificant jīva, low and of low conduct. How shall I know who the avatāra in Kali is?"

350 The Lord said, "We know the other avatāras through the scriptures; in the same way we accept the avatāra in Kali through the scriptures.

351 The words of an omniscient sage are the evidence of scripture (*pramāṇa*). For all of us jīvas, knowledge comes through the scriptures.

352 An avatāra does not say, 'I am an avatāra.' Knowing this, the sages examine His signs.

353 "The avatāras of You, who have no material body, are known among embodied beings by those incomparable, unsurpassed powers that no embodied being can possess." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.10.34)

354 By two kinds of characteristics — those of the essential nature (*svarūpa-lakṣaṇa*) and the marginal ones (*taṭastha-lakṣaṇa*) — the sages know a reality (*vastu*).

355 Form, nature and essential identity are the *svarūpa-lakṣaṇa*; knowledge gained through deeds is the *taṭastha-lakṣaṇa*.

356 At the beginning of the *Bhāgavatam*, in the auspicious invocation (*maṅgalācaraṇa*), Vyāsa defined the Supreme Lord by these two characteristics.

357 “Let us meditate on the Supreme Truth, from whom, directly and indirectly, this universe arises, endures and dissolves; who is fully aware of all purposes and shines by Himself (*svarāṭ*); who revealed the Veda through the heart to the first poet, Brahmā; about whom even the wise are bewildered; in whom, as fire, water and earth pass into one another, the threefold creation is real; and who by His own power is ever free of all deception.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.1.1)[44]

358 In this verse the word *param* defines Kṛṣṇa, and the word *satyam* states His *svarūpa-lakṣaṇa*.

359 From Him come the creation, maintenance and dissolution of the universe, and He taught the Veda to Brahmā; He knows all purposes, and by His own potency (*svarūpa-śakti*) He drives māyā far away.

360 All these activities are His *taṭastha-lakṣaṇa*. In the same way the sages know the other avatāras.

361 At the time of His descent He becomes perceptible to the world, and by these two characteristics some recognise the Lord.”

362 Sanātana said, “He in whom the Lord’s characteristics are found — a golden colour, and the work of giving prema and of saṅkīrtana —

363 is certainly Kṛṣṇa’s avatāra in the age of Kali. Tell me this for certain, so that my doubt may go.”

364 The Lord said, “Give up your cleverness, Sanātana. Hear the account of the *śaktyāveśa-avatāras*.

365 Kṛṣṇa’s *śaktyāveśa-avatāras* are countless. I shall give a glimpse, naming the chief among them.

366 *Śaktyāveśa* is of two kinds, primary and secondary. One endowed with the potency itself I call an avatāra; one endowed only with its reflection, a *vibhūti*.

367 Sanaka and his brothers, Nārada, Pṛthu, Paraśurāma, and Brahmā, who is a jīva, are called *āveśa-avatāras*.

368 Śeṣa in Vaikuṇṭha, and Ananta, who holds up the earth — these are primary *āveśa-avatāras*. To describe them in detail would have no end.

369 In Sanaka and his brothers is the potency of knowledge, in Nārada the potency of devotion, in Brahmā the potency of creation, and in Ananta the potency of holding up the earth.

370 In Śeṣa is the potency of serving the Lord Himself; in Pṛthu, the potency of maintaining the world; and in Paraśurāma, an infusion of prowess that destroys the wicked.

371 "Those into whom Janārdana has entered with a portion of His potency of knowledge and the rest are called *āveśa-avatāras*; they are in fact the greatest of jīvas." (Laghu-bhāgavatāmṛta, 1.18)

372 Those I call *vibhūtis* are described in the *Gītā* and in the Eleventh Canto: Kṛṣṇa pervades the world by investing beings with a reflection of His potency.[45]

373 "Whatever being is possessed of opulence, beauty or might — know that it is born from a part of My splendour." (Bhagavad-gītā, 10.41)

374 "But what need have you, Arjuna, of all this detailed knowledge? By one portion of Myself I pervade and support this entire universe." (Bhagavad-gītā, 10.42)[46]

375 Thus I have told you about the *śaktyāveśa-avatāras*. Now hear about the characteristics of His childhood (*bālya*) and boyhood (*paugaṇḍa*).

376 When the son of the king of Vraja, whose nature is the crown of youth (*kaiśora*), resolves to perform His manifest pastimes,

377 He first causes His mother, His father and His devotees to appear, and afterwards He Himself appears in the sequence of pastimes that begins with His birth.

378 "Though He has many ages, it is as a *kiśora*, in His youth, that He possesses all qualities; He is the shelter of all the rasas of devotion and ever enjoys His eternal pastimes." (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 2.1.63)

379 All His pastimes, beginning with the killing of Pūtanā, He eternally manifests moment by moment, one after another.

380 The universes are endless, beyond counting, and in one universe or another some pastime is being manifested.

381 In this way all the pastimes flow like the stream of the Gaṅgā, and the prince of Vraja manifests each of them.

382 Gradually He passes through childhood and boyhood and attains youth (*kaiśora*). He performs the rāsa and other pastimes, and in *kaiśora* He abides eternally.

383 All the scriptures declare that Kṛṣṇa's pastimes are eternal, but people cannot understand how a pastime can be eternal.

384 I shall give an example, so that people may understand: Kṛṣṇa's pastimes are eternal, as the circle of the luminaries shows.

385 The sun moves night and day through the circle of the luminaries, crossing the seven islands and their oceans step by step.

386 A night and a day measure sixty *daṇḍas*, or three thousand six hundred *palas*.

387 From sunrise the sun climbs step by step through sixty *palas*; that is one *daṇḍa*, and eight *daṇḍas* make a *prahara*.

388 Through one, two, three and four *praharas* it moves on to its setting, and when the four *praharas* of night have passed, the sun rises again.

389 In the same way, over fourteen *manvantaras* the circle of Kṛṣṇa's pastimes revolves step by step through the circle of the universes.

390 Kṛṣṇa's manifest presence lasts a hundred and twenty-five years, and during it He enjoys His pastimes in Vraja and in the cities, just as He did here.

391 Like a whirling firebrand, that wheel of pastimes revolves, and all the pastimes rise in turn in all the universes.

392 Birth, childhood, boyhood and youth are manifested in turn, with pastimes that begin with the killing of Pūtanā and end with the Mauṣala episode.

393 In one universe or another some pastime is always present; therefore the Vedas and Purāṇas call the pastimes eternal.

394 Goloka, the abode of Gokula, is all-pervading (*vibhu*), equal to Kṛṣṇa, and by Kṛṣṇa's will it descends into the universes.

395 Thus His pastimes go on eternally in Goloka, and in turn they become manifest in the universes.

396 In Vraja, where He manifests all His majesty, Kṛṣṇa is most complete (*pūrṇatama*); in the two cities He is more complete (*pūrṇatara*), and in Paravyoma complete (*pūrṇa*).

397 "Hari, whom works on drama celebrate with words such as 'best' and 'middling', is described in three ways: most complete, more complete and complete." (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 2.1.221)

398 "The wise regard Him in whom all qualities are manifest as most complete; Him who does not manifest them all as more complete; and Him who shows only a few as complete." (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 2.1.222)

399 "In Gokula Kṛṣṇa was revealed as most complete; in Dvārakā, Mathurā and elsewhere, as complete and more complete." (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 2.1.223)

400 This Kṛṣṇa in Vraja is Bhagavān most complete; all His other forms are called more complete or complete.

401 Thus I have briefly analysed Kṛṣṇa's forms (*svarūpa*). Even Ananta cannot tell all of it.

402 Kṛṣṇa's forms are endless, beyond counting. I have only pointed towards them, as one shows the moon by pointing to a branch (*śākhā-candra-nyāya*)."

403 Whoever hears or reads this is fortunate: he gains some knowledge of the truth of Kṛṣṇa's forms.

404 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.

Notes

1. *Anubhāṣya*: *nīca* — one absorbed in worldly things; *bhakti-śāstra-pravartaka* — an author of the scriptures of devotion. ↩
2. The same verse as Ādi 4.2; translation as there. ↩
3. The edition's heading: "The meeting with the chief of a band of robbers." ↩
4. The same verse as Ādi 1.63; translation as there. ↩
5. The same verse as Madhya 19.50; translation as there. Reference as in the edition's heading: *Hari-bhakti-vilāsa* 10.91. ↩
6. *Anubhāṣya*: these are the words of Prahlāda in his prayer to Lord Nṛsiṁha; the twelve qualities are those named in the previous verse (wealth, high birth, beauty, austerity, learning and the rest), or the twelve vows of a brāhmaṇa listed in the *Mahābhārata*. ↩
7. The edition's heading: "The Lord Himself sets forth to Sanātana the truth of *sambandha*, *abhidheya* and *prayojana* (the author's words)." ↩
8. Reference as in the edition's heading; Vṛndāvana Candra dāsa gives 1.2.103. *Anubhāṣya*: true religion (*sad-dharma*) is bhāgavata-dharma; *avabodhāya* — in order to know the truth, that is, to inquire about it. ↩
9. Reference as in the edition's heading; Vṛndāvana Candra dāsa gives 1.22.56. *Anubhāṣya*: the whole world, spiritual and material, is the potency of the Supreme Brahman, Kṛṣṇa. ↩
10. The same verse as Ādi 7.119; translation as there. ↩
11. The same verse as Madhya 6.155; translation as there. ↩
12. The same verse as Madhya 6.156; translation as there. ↩
13. The same verse as Ādi 7.118; translation as there. ↩
14. *Anubhāṣya*: the south is the path of karma (the hornets and wasps are the desires for enjoyment); the west, the path of mystic powers (or, in another view, of jñāna); the north, the path of jñāna or of yoga (the black python of *kaivalya*); the east, devotion to Kṛṣṇa — the treasure that already belongs to the jīva. ↩
15. The same verse as Ādi 17.76; translation as there. ↩
16. *Anubhāṣya*: "let them prattle" is said in mockery. Reference as in the edition's heading. ↩
17. The same verse as Ādi 2.95; translation as there. ↩
18. The same verse as Ādi 2.107; translation as there. ↩

19. The same verse as Ādi 2.67; translation as there. ↩
20. The same verse as Ādi 2.11; translation as there. ↩
21. The same verse as Ādi 2.14; translation as there. ↩
22. The same verse as Ādi 2.20; translation as there. ↩
23. The same verse as Ādi 1.71; translation as there. ↩
24. The edition's heading: these are Śrī Kṛṣṇa's words to Uddhava. ↩
25. The same verse as Ādi 4.146, but here the edition reads *sphuratu*, "may it shine forth" (there *sphurati*, "appears"); translation as there with this change. ↩
26. *Anubhāṣya*: Śrī Baladeva is Kṛṣṇa's *vaibhava-prakāśa*; differing in mood (that of a cowherd and that of a kṣatriya), He also appears in the original *catur-vyūha*, the four *prābhava-vilāsas*. ↩
27. *Anubhāṣya*: from Nārāyaṇa, the Lord of the spiritual sky, *catur-vyūhas* are manifest again as His enclosure on all sides. ↩
28. The edition's heading: the *nava-vyūha* is the enclosure of Mathurā and Dvārakā. ↩
29. *Anubhāṣya*: by the maxim of "the moon on the branch" one points to a branch of a tree to show where the moon is in the sky — it is only an indication of direction (*dig-darśana*). Though the avatāras can be seen by worldly eyes, they are not worldly: their pastimes are known only to the jīva who humbly follows them, never to worldly senses and logic. ↩
30. *Anubhāṣya*: Sūta Gosvāmī speaks to the sages headed by Śaunaka; *sattva-nidhi* is the shelter of all *sattva*, the treasure-house of pure *sattva*. ↩
31. The same verse as Ādi 5.77; translation as there. ↩
32. The edition's heading: He Himself, as Balarāma or Saṅkarṣaṇa, is the lord of the *sandhinī-śakti*. ↩
33. *Anubhāṣya*: these are Uddhava's words to Nanda and Yaśodā; *bīja-yonī* — the efficient and the material cause of the world: both the Puruṣa and *pradhāna* are these two; *jñāna* here means the jīva. ↩
34. The same verse as Ādi 5.84; translation as there. ↩
35. The same verse as Ādi 5.83; translation as there. ↩
36. *Anubhāṣya*: in Vaikuṇṭha only pure *sattva* (*śuddha-sattva*) operates; *apare*, "the rest", are passion, greed and all else that belongs to māyā. ↩
37. *Anubhāṣya*: Bhagavān Kapiladeva speaks to Devahūti, who has asked about the marks of *puruṣa* and *prakṛti*; the seed (*vīrya*) is the *jīva-śakti*, the womb (*yoni*) is *prakṛti*, and the *mahat-tattva* is the first transformation of *prakṛti*, the sprout of the universe in the form of *citta*. ↩
38. *Anubhāṣya*: Maitreya tells Vidura how the Puruṣa-avatāra creates the world through māyā and how the jīvas come forth from Him; *vīryavān*, "the potent

One”, is He who possesses the *cit-śakti*. ↩

39. The same verse as Ādi 5.71; translation as there. ↩
40. The same verse as Ādi 5.141; translation as there. ↩
41. The same verse as Ādi 3.36; translation as there. ↩
42. The same verse as Ādi 3.39; translation as there. ↩
43. The same verse as Ādi 3.51; translation as there. ↩
44. The same verse as Madhya 8.265; translation as there. ↩
45. *gītā-ekādaśe* is read here as “in the *Gītā* and in the Eleventh”: the *vibhūtis* are described in *Bhagavad-gītā* 10 and in *Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam* 11.16. ↩
46. The same verse as Ādi 2.20; translation as there. ↩